good any more, now that they had proposed an alternative head for the crown of Hindustan?

On 23 March 1567, only days after Akbar heard of their proclamation, he left Lahore for his final campaign against the mutinous Uzbek siblings, Ali Quli and Bahadur. As it happens, two of his elephants died on the way, both on the same day. Unperturbed, the padishah saw in this an omen for the end of the 'two unlucky brothers' of Jaunpur.[76]

He was not, it seems, inclined to flatter them with any show of anxious hurry in their pursuit. He 'indulged in hunting' all the way back from Lahore, writes Abul Fazl; halfway to Agra, he even stopped to witness a pilgrimage in Kurukshetra. A great crowd of pilgrims and ascetics had gathered around the town's lake – the pilgrims in prayer, the ascetics receiving alms, 'gold and silver, and jewels and stuffs'.[77] Suddenly, the cheerful bustle turned aggressive. Two groups of ascetics that had converged on Kurukshetra, the Kaurs and the Puris, were arguing over turf. The Puris had long been positioned along the banks of the lake, within easy and profitable reach of alms-givers emerging from a cleansing dip in its holy waters. The Kaurs wanted to take their place.

The two sects decided to settle the matter with their fists. Akbar did not object to such violent resolution to the dispute; perhaps he even saw an omen in it. He, too, was going to battle a rival for land. As the ascetics began to bombard each other with rocks and arrows, the padishah pitched in to even their chances, lending some of his own men to the Puris, who were outnumbered by the Kaurs. The Puris won the day, and Akbar, having 'delighted [in the] sport' with all the gusto of an ancient Roman at the Colosseum, resumed his journey.[78]

At this leisurely pace, it was the first week of May before Akbar finally gathered his men and his elephants, and set out from Agra. As on his previous expedition to Jaunpur, summer had set in; the sun so hot, writes Badauni, 'that the marrow of creatures melted in their bones'.

A month later, marching in the relative cool of night, the Mughal army reached Rae Bareli, and news arrived that Ali Quli and Bahadur were heading to Gwalior. Catching scent of his prey, Akbar was no longer languid but tense for the chase. Despite objections from his courtiers,[79] on the evening of 7 June 1567, Akbar galloped away from his own camp.